

Bow & Tie — Launch Cost Sheet & Go-Live Checklist

Handcrafted hair accessories · Dhaka, Bangladesh · prepared 13 July 2026

This document lists everything needed to take **bowandtie** officially live, what each item costs, and a step-by-step tick-box checklist. Costs are approximate — BDT first, USD in brackets (~৳120 = \$1). Free-tier services are marked **Free**.

Part 1 — Cost breakdown

1. Technical (running the website)

Item	Service	Cost	Notes
Frontend hosting	Cloudflare Pages / Vercel	Free	Cloudflare Pages best for a commercial store
Backend API	Render (free)	Free	Sleeps after 15 min idle → keep awake with a free pinger
Backend upgrade (optional)	Render Starter	~৳840/mo (\$7)	Removes cold-starts — worth it once orders arrive
Database	Neon Postgres (free)	Free	0.5 GB — plenty for a boutique
Image storage	Cloudflare R2 (free)	Free	10 GB, no bandwidth fees (card required, not charged)
Email	Brevo (free)	Free	300 emails/day
SSL / HTTPS	Let's Encrypt (automatic)	Free	Included by all hosts
Uptime pinger	UptimeRobot	Free	Stops the free backend sleeping
Domain name	Namecheap .com	~৳1,300/yr (\$11)	Or .com.bd via BTCL ~৳800–2,000/yr

Technical cost to go live: ~৳1,300/year — just the domain. Everything else is free.

2. Login, social & messaging APIs (all free)

Item	Cost	Status in your store	Notes
Google Sign-In (OAuth)	Free	Live	Just a free Google Cloud project — no billing card, no per-user charge at any scale
Facebook Login (OAuth)	Free	Coded, off (Google-only chosen)	Needs a free Meta developer app; enable anytime
WhatsApp Cloud API (Meta)	Free tier	Coded, paused	Service replies free; only paid template/marketing messages cost (optional)
Facebook / Instagram page & Shop	Free	—	Organic selling / traffic channel
Google Analytics (optional)	Free	—	Traffic & sales insights

All login and API integrations are free. The only Meta-related cost is optional paid advertising (see \$5). Google/Facebook charge nothing for authentication.

3. Business accounts (for taking payments)

Item	Cost	Required for	Notes
bKash Merchant account	Free signup	Accepting bKash properly	~1.5–1.85% per cash-out
TIN (Tax ID, NBR)	Free	Only if you later add SSLCommerz	Apply online at NBR
Business bank account	Free–low	SSLCommerz settlement (later)	Some banks need a minimum balance
Trademark (brand name) (optional)	~ ₹4,000+	Protecting the "Bow & Tie" name	Not required to launch

These are all free (or optional). Note: an automated SSLCommerz account later requires a trade license — but you don't need one to launch on COD + manual bKash.

4. Payment & delivery (pay only when you sell — no upfront cost)

Item	Cost	Notes
Cash on Delivery + manual bKash/Nagad	Free	Already built — you can launch on this today
SSLCommerz (automated checkout)	No monthly fee; ~2.5–3% per transaction	Needs trade license + bank + TIN. Add later.
Courier (Pathao / Steadfast / RedX)	~ ₹60–130 per parcel	Free signup; usually charged to the customer as shipping

5. Optional / growth (not needed to launch)

Item	Cost	Notes
Render Starter (no cold-start)	~₳840/mo	Recommended once orders come in
Facebook / Instagram ads	Your budget	Main growth lever for a boutique
Professional logo / branding	~₳2,000–10,000 one-time	Optional
Custom email (<code>hello@bowandtie.com</code>)	Free (Cloudflare/Zoho free tier)	Nice for professionalism

Part 2 — Three budget scenarios

Scenario	What you get	First-year cost	Monthly
● A — Absolute minimum	Free stack + free subdomain + COD/manual bKash	₳0	₳0
● B — Recommended launch ★	Everything in A + your own domain	~₳1,300 (domain only)	₳0
● C — Smooth, sales-ready	Everything in B + Render Starter + SSLCommerz	~₳11,400	~₳840 + 2.5–3% on gateway sales

Bottom line: you can be live and taking real orders for **the price of a domain (~₳1,300/year)** — everything else in the launch stack is free. Payments and courier cost nothing upfront; they are per-sale and mostly passed to the customer.

Part 3 — Go-live checklist

Work top to bottom. Nothing here has a monthly cost unless noted.

Phase 1 — Business accounts

- ☐ Register / upgrade a **bKash Merchant** account for taking payments
- ☐ (Only for SSLCommerz later) Get a free **TIN** and confirm a **business bank account**

Phase 2 — Infrastructure (all free)

- ☐ Confirm the site is deployed: **Vercel/Cloudflare** (frontend) + **Render** (backend) + **Neon** (database)
- ☐ Set up **Cloudflare R2** and add the 5 env vars on Render (so product images survive redeloys — see `DEPLOY.md`)
- ☐ Set `ADMIN_EMAIL` and `ADMIN_PASSWORD` on Render (stop using the demo `admin123`)
- ☐ Add a free **UptimeRobot** monitor hitting `/api/health` every 10 min (stops the backend sleeping)
- ☐ Confirm **Brevo** email is sending (order confirmations, verification)

Phase 3 — Domain & branding (~₳1,300/yr)

- ☐ Buy a **domain** (Namecheap `.com` or `.com.bd`)
- ☐ Point the domain's DNS at the frontend host

- ☐ Update backend **CORS_ORIGIN** and **APP_URL** to the new domain
- ☐ Add the new domain to **Google OAuth** authorised origins
- ☐ (Optional) Set up a free custom email like **hello@bowandtie.com**

Phase 4 — Products & content

- ☐ Fill in the **product import Excel template** (**product-import/** folder)
- ☐ Bulk-import products via **Admin → Products → Import**
- ☐ Upload product images (*safe now that R2 is on*)
- ☐ Review categories, prices, stock, and descriptions
- ☐ Set up any launch **coupons / promotions**

Phase 5 — Payments & delivery

- ☐ Launch with **Cash on Delivery + manual bKash/Nagad** (*already built — \$0*)
- ☐ Sign up with a **courier** (Pathao / Steadfast / RedX) and add credentials
- ☐ (Later) Apply for **SSLCommerz** once the trade license is ready, for automated checkout

Phase 6 — Final checks before announcing

- ☐ Place a **real test order** end-to-end and confirm the email + admin alert
- ☐ Check the site on **mobile** (most customers shop on phones)
- ☐ Verify **shipping rates** (inside vs outside Dhaka) and free-shipping threshold
- ☐ Add store **policies**: returns, delivery time, contact info
- ☐ Connect **Facebook / Instagram** and prepare launch posts

Phase 7 — Grow (optional, after launch)

- ☐ Upgrade to **Render Starter** (~\$840/mo) to remove cold-starts
- ☐ Enable **SSLCommerz** automated payments
- ☐ Start **Facebook/Instagram ads**
- ☐ Set up **WhatsApp** order alerts / customer messages (free tier)
- ☐ (Optional) Enable **Facebook Login** alongside Google (both free)

Free stack: Cloudflare Pages · Render · Neon · Cloudflare R2 · Brevo · UptimeRobot. The only fixed cost to go live is a domain (~\$1,300/year).